

29th February was not originally a leap day – the Julian calendar added the extra day after 24th February.



Gregory's reforms

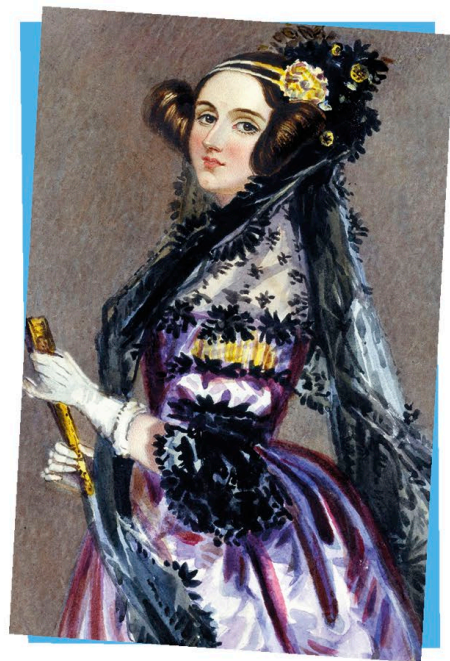
By the 16th century, the difference between an actual solar year and the Julian calendar had drifted by about 10 days. This happened because the length of a year is not exactly 365.25 days – it's closer to 365.24 days. The Roman Catholic pope, Gregory XIII, introduced the Gregorian calendar in 1582. Among other adjustments, ten days were cut from the calendar to bring the date back into line with a solar year. So in 1582 the day after Thursday 4th October was Friday 15th October.

Over the next couple of centuries, most nations using the Julian calendar converted to the Gregorian system, though Russia and Greece didn't switch until the 20th century. The difference between the dates of the Julian

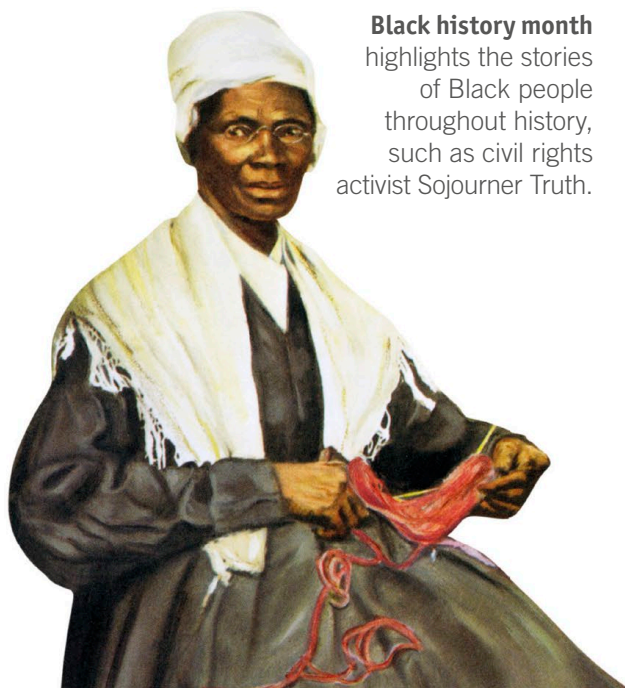
and Gregorian calendars means that a day may have had one date in one country, and a date ten or more days later in another. For the purposes of this book, we have given the dates that were being used in the relevant country at the time – whether that was the Julian or Gregorian calendar.

Forgotten histories

Keeping track of different calendars can be an issue, but is not the only problem facing a day-by-day history. Traditionally, history has been written by those in power, so the stories of people from marginalized groups are not well documented. However, in recent years, there has been an enthusiastic interest in reclaiming these lost histories, bringing the stories of women, Black people, and other groups to a wider audience. We have included as many of these stories in this book as we can.



Ada Lovelace Day was set up in 2009 to celebrate the achievements of this computing pioneer, and all women in STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics) careers.



Black history month highlights the stories of Black people throughout history, such as civil rights activist Sojourner Truth.